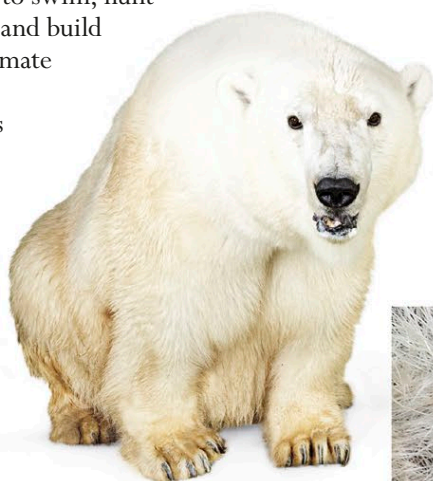


POLAR BEAR

Ursus maritimus

This magnificent animal is as at home at sea as on land. It is the world's largest terrestrial predator, and its huge bulk can make it seem lumbering. In the water, however, it is transformed into a creature of effortless grace. Polar bears are true nomads and spend much of the year far from land, roaming the frozen expanse of the Arctic Ocean. In summer the melting ice forces them to retreat to land, where they sometimes come into contact with humans. Young polar bears are born in the middle of winter in a den dug by their mother. She scarcely wakes when they are born and nurses them in her sleep for three months, breaking down her own body reserves to create rich, fatty milk. Come the spring, the cubs have increased their birth weight dramatically, while the mother is close to starvation. She spends the next two years teaching them to swim, hunt seals, defend themselves, and build their own snow dens. Climate change is threatening the habitat and feeding habits of polar bears, which could result in this species' extinction.

SIZE 1.8–2.8 m (6–9¼ ft)
HABITAT Arctic ice fields
DISTRIBUTION Arctic Ocean; polar regions of Russia, Alaska, Canada, Norway, and Greenland
DIET Mainly seals



unlike other bears, the polar bear has a slightly convex "Roman" nose



FURRY EARS >

The small ears are completely covered with fur to prevent frostbite. Polar bears have good hearing but rely mainly on their sense of smell to locate their prey.



< DARK EYE

The dark eyes and nose are the most conspicuous parts of the bear's body. Polar bears have good eyesight, comparable to that of humans.



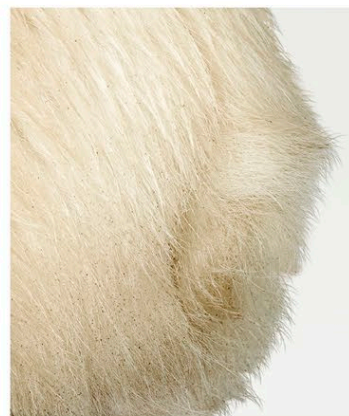
^ CRUSHING BLOW

The front paws are the principle means of dispatching prey. Polar bears can smell seals below the ice and break into their lairs by rising up on their hind legs and crashing down with their forepaws. Then, they grab the seal and pull it out.



^ INSULATED PAWS

Polar bears have fur on the soles of their feet, which insulates them against the cold. The furry soles also help to prevent slipping when walking on ice.



^ STUBBY TAIL

The polar bear has little use for a long tail, so the appendage is reduced to a stub – all but hidden in the dense fur.

